

The Diversities of Tongues

If you and I are really going to understand the importance that diversities of tongues plays in God's government, then we are going to have to take it from the Word of God.

Follow me very closely. If you understand what I am about to tell you about the basics of prayer, you will never again let anybody discredit or remove diverse tongues from its important place in the government of God. Nor will you ever again let people talk you out of the importance of praying in the Holy Ghost.

My Father has promised me this, and I can pass it on to you: if you continue faithful in getting to know God by His Spirit, then five years from now you will not look back over your life and find that it has been one day like the next, one month like the next, until three or four years slipped by and you remained defeated and unchanged from the time you entered in.

If you pursue Him by the Spirit, then five years will not go by without growth and change in your personal life.

So let us look very closely at the role that diverse tongues plays in His government and in His ability to set us free.

Look at 1 Corinthians 12:1:

Now concerning spiritual gifts, brethren, I would not have you ignorant.

As I have said many times before, that makes us even. If there is one area I do not want to be ignorant in, it is concerning the operation of the gifts of the Spirit.

To be frank, that is one area where this generation seems shy. But one thing you can rest assured of: when Paul makes a statement like, "Concerning spiritual gifts, brethren, I would not have you ignorant," before he finishes the chapter he will supply enough information to eradicate our ignorance.

As faith people, as Pentecostal people, we pride ourselves in knowing all about the nine gifts of the Spirit. It is too bad we do not pride ourselves more in knowing how to operate in them.

One thing we know for sure is that there are nine gifts of the Spirit. But these nine gifts empower, or supply the power and qualification for, eight total operations of God. These eight operations are divided into three categories.

How do I know this? I know it by the Spirit of God because of mysteries.

Paul says:

Now ye are the body of Christ, and members in particular.

That simply means I am an individual member in a vast Body called the Body of Christ.

How many of you are born again? How many are filled with the Holy Ghost? Then right now you are called and separated in your spirit to fill one or more of these eight operations.

It would behoove you to listen very closely, because one of these operations I am about to read is yours. You are called to fill it powerfully by the power of the Holy Spirit.

Do you know which one it is? No, I do not know either. That measure of faith has been placed on the inside of you in seed form. It is in your seed, not mine. But you are called to fill one or more of these eight operations, and they are listed in divine order.

First Corinthians 12:28 says:

And God hath set some in the church, first apostles, secondarily prophets, thirdly teachers, after that miracles, then gifts of healings, helps, governments, diversities of tongues.

First apostles. Secondarily prophets. Thirdly teachers. After that, miracles, which is the fourth operation. Gifts of healings is the fifth operation. Helps and governments are the sixth and seventh operations. The eighth operation is diversities of tongues.

One complete operation of God is called diversities of tongues.

The offices we hear the most about are pastor, evangelist, and teacher. We hear some about the office of the prophet, though I am sad to report that many reports about prophets in our day are not about prophets qualified by the Holy Ghost, but about self-acclaimed prophets.

Kenneth Hagin was a prophet. We hear about the office of the apostle. They say T. L. Osborn was an apostle. William Branham was a prophet. We know about these offices. We know about helps and governments.

But the operation we do not know very much about is the operation, or office, of the diversities of tongues.

Why do we not know much about it? It is listed in the government of God. In the nine gifts of the Spirit, diversities of tongues is listed as a gift. Why do we know so little about it?

The devil is so afraid of it that he has been running around the country trying to discredit it.

One group says, "You are not getting anywhere with God praying in tongues unless you are in a warring tongue and shouting at the devil."

The problem with that is that the Word of God says when you pray in tongues, you are not talking to men, but to God. You do not need to shout tongues at Him because He is not deaf. And in case you did shout tongues at Him, He is not nervous either.

If you think you are producing more for the Kingdom by shouting in tongues than you are by praying under your breath, you are not. He is creating the supernatural language in your spirit. You did not create it. He created it. The moment it comes out of your mouth, it is released to God.

Whether you whisper it or scream it makes no difference. The word that comes out of your spirit in tongues still means the same thing whether you shouted it or whispered it, because you are talking to God.

Where do the emotions come from? They are added when the tongue passes through the soul realm.

I do not mind adding emotions. Sometimes I get excited and scare some of you. What do I do when I get excited? That is an emotion. Sometimes intercession comes on me, and I feel all this power pouring out of my spirit. It slides me in to stand in the gap for something. Incredible amounts of power flow through a person at that time.

The devil has tried to utterly confuse tongues because he wants you to get discouraged over it and quit using it altogether.

Yet a whole operation of God is given to it.

Many of the gifts of the Spirit qualify an operation. For example, the prophet will operate in many gifts: word of knowledge, word of wisdom, workings of miracles, prophecy, and others. Many gifts qualify his office.

But an entire operation in God's government was given to the diversities of tongues. The question is why.

Notice Paul called it diverse tongues. That means different supernatural flows or manifestations of tongues.

The one I am most familiar with is tongues for my own personal edification, and I know that is the one you are most familiar with.

The second one we are most familiar with is tongues for interpretation, which we see in public assemblies.

The third is tongues that extends itself into deep intercessional groanings of the Spirit.

The fourth is tongues that presents itself as a sign to the unbeliever, when He empowers you to testify, preach, or witness in any language on the face of the earth that you had no previous knowledge of. When you start preaching in someone's native language, a language you did not know, that is a sign to the unbeliever personified.

That is why He calls it diverse tongues. It is an entire operation of God, and it has been placed into His government to serve a purpose. To deny it is to deny the perfecting of the Body of Christ.

So let us find out why God would donate an entire operation to the diversities of tongues.

To understand this, we need to divide the operations into three categories.

The first category is apostle, prophet, teacher, preacher, and evangelist. Workings of miracles and gifts of healings also fit in that category, because in the offices of workings of miracles, gifts of healings, and teacher, the pastor and evangelist are also encompassed. The pastor will many times also hold the teacher's office.

So apostle, prophet, teacher, workings of miracles, and gifts of healings form the first category, which also includes evangelist and pastor. That category is given for the maturing of the saints.

The reason is that we handle the Word of God. The Word brings you from milk to strong meat and is given to you for maturing, for the increase of your faith, and for instruction and correction.

The second category is helps and governments. Helps and governments are given for the work of the ministry.

That brings us to the third category. In category three is a category all to itself with four diversities. Category three is diversities of tongues, and diversities of tongues is given for the edifying of the Body of Christ.

To see this more clearly, go to Ephesians 4:10:

He that descended is the same also that ascended up far above all heavens, that he might fill all things.

Then Paul says:

And he gave some, apostles; and some, prophets; and some, evangelists; and some, pastors and teachers.

There is your fivefold ministry. What did He give them for?

Verse 12 says:

For the perfecting of the saints...

That means the maturing of the saints.

It took me a long time because people tried to fight me out of the revelation of praying in tongues. Strong people said you can get messed up from praying in tongues too much. They tried to counsel me. Actually, it was not so much counsel as contention, because I would not take counsel. If you try to talk me out of praying, I will not take your counsel.

People ran away from the prayer center saying, "They put too much emphasis on prayer."

Let us divide this north from south and go clear to one extreme: what is wrong with prayer? What are you fighting?

People tried to contend, discourage, preach, and teach against it. When tongues and prayer began picking up momentum, people felt obligated to stand up and bring correction to the poor Body of Christ about overextending themselves in prayer.

For a long time, I heard the government of God taught according to Ephesians 4 by many who seemed to be somewhat among them. The way they taught government was exciting to me, and I can tell you why.

They taught this to me when I first entered phase two and God exploded me onto the camp meeting scene. Deep down inside, for the first few years, I began to think I was something among them.

Thank God He has healed me since then.

My wife was the first one to catch it. Wives usually see it first when you start getting funny.

I was in a big camp meeting in Omaha, Nebraska, and I was the low man on the pole. They brought me in and put me wherever they wanted. Even though I did get some night meetings, I usually ended up with the afternoon ones. You know, the meetings where everybody eats and wants to sleep between services.

But I did not mind. God began giving so much during those meetings that finally the man in charge came and said, "We would like you to receive the offerings in about every service, even though the other men are going to speak."

I said, "Okay."

Some of the other ministers would come into the service the way I sometimes do in camp meetings, during the song service, just praying and staying in the Spirit until I walk up front. But they were not coming in during the time I was receiving the offering, and it was starting to get to me.

We were riding in an elevator, and one little sheep spoke out over the heads of the people and said, "Boy, they ought to hear you teach."

I said, "Yeah, if they had hung around long enough, they would."

My wife caught it, and she got me.

The teaching I was receiving on government was not helping my situation. Every time I heard government taught, my head got a little fatter, because I thought myself to be more somewhat among them each time.

This is the way they taught government: He gave apostles, prophets, teachers, evangelists, and pastors for the maturing of the saints, for the work of the ministry, and for the edifying of the Body of Christ.

I do not know how many times I have been introduced as, "God has given him to us as a gift to the Body of Christ, for the maturing of the saints so they can do the work of the ministry, so the Body of Christ will be edified."

But it all went back up the ladder to how great we were, that we were special gifts given to you for your maturing so you could do the work of the ministry so the Church would be edified. The whole reason you were edified and matured was supposedly because of the great gift that resided down on the inside of me.

Thank God that if I keep praying in the Holy Ghost and speaking mysteries up to the Father, He will straighten me out.

God sent me for a long run on a short rope, and it jerked the slack out of me. Then, when He revealed to my spirit through a mystery the role that diversities of tongues played in His government, I was shocked. It was in these last two years. I said, "Oh my God. You were not exalting us at all."

I have been put in rooms with somebody assigned next to me. If I had any little need, I would pick up the phone, and this person was the gopher. That was all he would do: run for me. There would be a car waiting with a driver standing by. I have been picked up in Rolls-Royces and Mercedes-Benzes. I have been protected from crowds so much that at times they would not even let my own family in when my family said who they were. I would find out about it later, and it would irritate the fire out of me.

That is how protected we were in our great office that supposedly had been given to you for your maturing so you could do the work of the ministry for the edifying of the Body.

But that was not what He was saying.

He was saying that you are also a precious gift to the Body, and that your calling and office are every bit as important as mine. In fact, I have been called to be more of a servant to you than you to me.

We are not talking about you walking on my back as a mat. I am talking about God calling me to serve spiritual things to you from His table. That is my job for your maturing. But your office is just as important as mine, and you should be treated with no more disrespect than I.

Does He say all of that? Yes, He says it right here.

Look again at Ephesians 4:11:

And he gave some, apostles; and some, prophets; and some, evangelists; and some, pastors and teachers.

That is the first category: apostle, prophet, teacher, preacher, workers of miracles, and gifts of healings. The first category was given for the perfecting of the saints, or the maturing of the saints. We handle the Word: apostle, prophet, teacher, preacher, evangelist. We are given for the maturing of the saints.

What was the second category? Helps and governments.

What are helps and governments given for? For the work of the ministry. What does verse 12 say after "the perfecting of the saints"? It says, "for the work of the ministry."

Then what is the third category? Diversities of tongues.

What was it given for? The last part of verse 12 says, "for the edifying of the body of Christ."

Then verse 13 says:

| Till we all come in the unity of the faith...

Now you tell me: if we exclude the third category, the eighth operation, diversities of tongues, which He listed along with the fivefold ministry for the maturing of the saints and along with helps and governments for the work of the ministry, how are we going to come to the unity of the faith?

Go on and downplay it if you want. But if we exclude it, how will we ever come into the unity of the faith?

Let me help you understand it a little more.

Ephesians 4 says He ascended on high, led captivity captive, and gave gifts unto men. As He rose from the dead, He ascended on high with His blood, sat down at the right hand of the Father, and said, "It is finished." Then He began to fill all in all, the entire Body of Christ, with His gifts.

For the sake of teaching, let us say hypothetically that He ascended three different times, one for each category. We know He only ascended once and gave gifts unto men, but to help clarify it, suppose He ascended three times.

The first time, He took a handful of gifts and threw them into His newly formed Body on the earth. He gave apostles, prophets, teachers, pastors, evangelists, workings of miracles, and gifts of healings. Among the Body of Christ, certain people stood up and said, "I am an apostle." Another said, "The gift of the prophet landed on me." Another said, "The gift of teaching has landed upon me." Another said, "The pastoral gift has landed on me." Out of a crowd of ten thousand, perhaps a hundred stood up and said, "We have received these gifts."

Jesus looked the Body over and said, "It is not enough. It is not enough for the operation of the Body of Christ. I must ascend and grab another handful."

So He ascended and got a whole handful of helps and governments and threw them into the Body. Thousands and thousands of people stood up and said, "My God, I have received the gift of helps. I have received the gift of governments."

He said, "Now I can use these people to carry on the work of the ministry around the soul winning, teaching, and maturing being carried on by the fivefold."

Then He looked them over and said, "It is not enough. They still have to learn to operate out of My Spirit."

So He ascended on high again, got a whole handful of diversities of tongues, came back down, and threw them into the Body. Suddenly every person out there stood up and said, "I have received tongues for personal edification."

A whole group said, "I have received tongues for prophecy."

Another group lifted their hands and said, "I have received tongues for deep intercessional groanings."

Still a few who stood in evangelism and other callings said, "I have received tongues as a sign to the unbeliever, so that when I preach, He takes me over and I start preaching in their native tongue."

But all of them received tongues for edification.

If we are all going to come into the unity of the faith, then we need to learn how to activate the Holy Spirit, the Teacher He has placed on the inside of us, who is more than willing to pray hour after hour in divine secrets and mysteries before the Father. He does this so you can build yourself spiritually into the operation God separated you to at your rebirth.

He gave the eighth operation for the edification of the saints until we all come into the unity of the faith.

We have heard exquisite teaching on the offices of apostle, prophet, preacher, evangelist, pastor, and teacher, and on their roles in bringing us into the unity of the faith. Extensive teachings have been written on the offices we hold.

Books have been written about helps and governments, with extensive teaching on the role helps and governments play in the maturing of the saints.

But where, my friend, is the extended teaching on the role diversities of tongues plays in the edification of the Body of Christ?

It takes all three categories for you and me to arrive at the unity of the faith. Where is the extended teaching?

For when I call you and separate you through ordination, through an operation which I have placed in you, says the Spirit, My power will qualify you to fulfill that office from within.

For I have made all things possible to him that believes. Therefore, approach not My presence in your own understanding, nor in the ideas, creeds, and doctrines men would put forth. I have placed within you truth and an anointing which cannot lie. It is truth and will teach you all things.

Put yourself to My Spirit for the purposes of edification, and I will lift you up. I will build you into every operation I have separated you to and qualify you by My power, says the Spirit of grace.

Hear, My child.

Hallelujah. Hallelujah. Hallelujah.

Let me tell you: there is not enough glory that goes with the eighth operation for the flesh to want it.

"I want you to lock yourself up where nobody knows about it, hour after hour."

Where is the glory in that?

We get a lot of glory in the office of the apostle, the office of the prophet, the office of the teacher, and especially in workings of miracles. There is lots and lots of glory there.

Why does nobody want to operate in the eighth operation? There is no glory.

So what do we do? We run around year after year changing churches. Why? Because we were the ones who needed change, so we traded them in.

When are we going to stop and start transforming to what we are hearing? When are you going to plant your feet on the Rock and say, "I am tired of getting shoved around. This is the devil's Waterloo. I am going to meet him right here on the Rock. We are going to wage war until I start coming out of it, because I am not running anymore. I am not changing my circumstances anymore. I am going to stand and fight."

He gave you the eighth operation, plus the Word of God, plus all the rest of it, so you can stand and fight with it.

He said, "I have given you this entire operation for your edification. Why will you not use it?"

Someone says, "I am busy scratching out a living. I work fourteen hours."

Unless you want to work fourteen hours the rest of your life, I would put in a couple of hours later, because those two hours will change the fourteen.

What do I think about praying in tongues in its basics? I will tell you what I think about it.

Some of you are frustrated. You have been beating the air so long that your confidence has been destroyed. You have jumped from church to church looking for answers, and I am glad you landed here. I did not get you saved, so I know somebody else did.

We jump from place to place. We do not like the counsel one person gives us, so we go get it from another. Do you know what we are looking for? We are looking for somebody who will agree with us. But watch out, because he usually wants your money.

We jump around and get counsel here or there from somebody who will identify more with us and our problem and the way we believe.

Do you think I could not tickle your ears? Do you think I could not conform myself to the most popular doctrines and get people in? That is what everybody is after. I could do it. But that would not mean I had your best interest at heart.

If I love you, I will teach you how to take a stand and put your feet on the Rock and say, "No more. Just changing my circumstances has not been the answer. I have to stop somewhere and make my fight. I have to begin to transform to the Word of God I have been hearing so it can release my ministry.

"I want to be fruitful. I do not want to live with my eyes barely peeking above the water. I want to enter in and fight this war."

That is why, in the government of God, we have introduced so strongly the third category, the eighth operation, which supplies its part in bringing us into the unity of the faith. That is the diversities of tongues.

It is the Holy Spirit's continual speaking of mysteries and divine secrets through your spirit that causes the Word of God to come alive in you. It causes the edification of the Body of Christ, purges us from the things that are unlovely in us, teaches us to love each other, and brings us into unity supplied by the power of the Holy Spirit.

I wanted to go on to the end of the chapter, but I feel I cannot, because I am too far over in the Spirit.

You cannot come here at seven o'clock on Sunday mornings and spend three hours in prayer, come on Wednesday nights and spend two or three hours in prayer, or spend your days riding around in your car praying in tongues without something very deep and heavy taking place.

God's third category in His Body is working wonderfully in you. Your seed is germinating. The imagery is coming out. Stalks and leaves are forming, and little fruits begin to form.

That is when joy, peace, and longsuffering begin to come forth in your life, until the great joys and peace of serving God are delivered to you.

Stay in. That does not even count the revival you and I are going to have here.

I had a whole second half, but I cannot get into it.

Are you understanding better the role diversities of tongues plays in His government?